湖南文理学院

On the Teaching of Self-directed Reading Texts

A Case Study of Units 2 & 4, Grade 8 Chinese Textbook

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Section 1

Background and Significance



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Research Background

Policy Context

- The unified Chinese textbook builds a tripartite reading system: *guided reading — self-directed reading — extensive reading*;
- Self-directed texts bridge teacher guidance and autonomous reading;
- The curriculum standards emphasize independent reading competence.

Practical Dilemmas

- Self-directed texts are often taught exactly like guided ones;
- Students' agency is weak, and strategy transfer stays limited.

Significance

Theoretical Value

- Enriches research on self-directed text teaching;
- Grounds the tripartite reading system in practice.

Practical Value

- Offers actionable strategies for frontline teachers;
- Fosters autonomous construction of reading ability.

Cf. *Chinese Curriculum Standards for Compulsory Education (2022)* [1].

Section 2

Contents and Methods



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Research Contents

- Analyze the arrangement of self-directed texts in Units 2 and 4;

Key Concept

Self-directed text: text types read mainly autonomously, with the teacher acting as a facilitator, emphasizing the transfer of reading strategies [3].

Research Contents

- Analyze the arrangement of self-directed texts in Units 2 and 4;
- Investigate current teaching practices and problems;

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- Analyze the arrangement of self-directed texts in Units 2 and 4;
- Investigate current teaching practices and problems;
- Propose principles and strategies for self-directed text teaching;

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Research Contents

- Analyze the arrangement of self-directed texts in Units 2 and 4;
- Investigate current teaching practices and problems;
- Propose principles and strategies for self-directed text teaching;
- Design lesson cases and reflect on classroom practice.

Key Concept

Self-directed text: text types read mainly autonomously, with the teacher acting as a facilitator, emphasizing the transfer of reading strategies [3].

Research Methods

Table 1: Overview of research methods

Method	Sample	Purpose
Literature review	42 journal papers	Map the research field
Questionnaire	320 participants	Profile current practice
Classroom observation	12 lessons	Analyze teaching behavior
Case analysis	6 lesson designs	Distill practical strategies

Data Analysis Example

Survey statistics (excerpt)

Class-level means of reading self-efficacy ($n = 320$):

$$\bar{X} = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i, \qquad S = \sqrt{\frac{1}{n-1}\sum_{i=1}^{n}(x_i - \bar{X})^2} \tag{1}$$

Pre-post differences are examined with paired t-tests[2].

Analysis script (excerpt)

```
import pandas as pd
data = pd.read_excel("reading_survey.xlsx")
mean, std = data["score"].mean(), data["score"].std()
print(f"mean = {mean:.2f}, std = {std:.2f}")
```

Section 3

Strategies and Practice



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   - Teaching Principles
   - Lesson Design
   - Practical Effects

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Principles of Self-directed Text Teaching

1. **Student agency** — give classroom time back to readers;
2. **Strategy transfer** — reuse strategies from guided reading;
3. **Assessment-driven** — task sheets and reading logs as engines;
4. **Integration** — link in-class self-directed reading with extensive reading.

Side notes as scaffolding

The side notes in self-directed texts provide thinking scaffolds; teachers should help students *learn to ask questions* with them until independent reading is achieved.

Lesson Design: *Return of the Wild Geese*

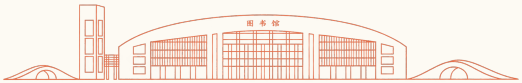


Fig.: Library of HUAS (illustrative material)

Lead-in	Short video on bird migration;
Reading	Task sheet with side notes;
Sharing	Group reports and peer questioning;
Transfer	Comparative reading of another text;
Homework	A 300-word observation note.

Practical Effects

Classroom observation

- Independent reading time rose from 8 to 18 minutes per lesson;
- Student-initiated questions grew from 21% to 57%;
- Completion rate of strategy-transfer tasks increased by 32%.

A caveat

Self-directed does not mean “hands-off”: teacher feedback remains the guarantee of reading quality.

Section 4

Conclusion and Outlook



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Conclusion and Outlook

Conclusions

- Self-directed text teaching should return to autonomous reading;
- Task sheets + side-note scaffolds + comparative reading work well;
- Integrated design of the tripartite reading system deserves study.

Future work

- Quasi-experimental studies with larger samples;
- IT-supported assessment of self-directed classrooms.

References I

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Thank You!

Q & A

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